

136

The woman at the well

A Samaritan woman came for water and went home to tell her town about the Christ.

At midday a Samaritan woman came to draw water at Jacob's well near Sychar. A tired Jewish traveller sitting there asked her for a drink. It was Jesus. In one conversation he crossed three walls: Jew and Samaritan, man and woman, teacher and a woman with a troubled past. He offered her "living water," told her the truth about her life, and plainly said he was the Messiah. She left her waterpot and ran to tell the town. Scripture never names her, yet she brought a whole town to Jesus.

At a glance

Name	Not given in Scripture
People	A Samaritan (John 4:9)
Home	Sychar, a city of Samaria (John 4:5)
Life	Five husbands; the man she now had was not her husband (John 4:18)
When	c. AD 28–29, early in Jesus' ministry
Main passages	John 4:1–42
New Testament	Only in John's Gospel

"But whosoever drinketh of the water that I shall give him shall never thirst; but the water that I shall give him shall be in him a well of water springing up into everlasting life."

John 4:14, KJV

The life of The woman at the well

The date is approximate (AD) and follows the house chronology, with the crucifixion c. AD 30. John places the story soon after Jesus' first Passover in Jerusalem.

- c. AD 28–29** ● **A request for water**
The sixth hour
On his way from Judea to Galilee, Jesus rests, wearied, at Jacob's well. A woman of Samaria comes to draw water, and he says, "Give me to drink." She is astonished that a Jew would ask this of her. *John 4:1–9*
- At the well** ● **Living water**
Jesus offers "living water" that becomes a well springing up into everlasting life. She asks for this water so she need not keep coming to draw, still thinking of the well. *John 4:10–15*
- At the well** ● **Her life laid bare**
Jesus tells her to call her husband. When she says she has none, he names her five husbands. She calls him a prophet and raises the old question of where to worship. *John 4:16–20*
- At the well** ● **The Messiah revealed**
Jesus says true worshippers will worship the Father "in spirit and in truth." When she speaks of the coming Messiah, Jesus says, "I that speak unto thee am he." *John 4:21–26*
- The same day** ● **She tells the town**
She leaves her waterpot and goes into the city: "Come, see a man, which told me all things that ever I did: is not this the Christ?" The people go out to him. *John 4:27–30*
- Two days** ● **Many believe**
Many Samaritans believe because of her words. Jesus stays two days, and many more believe his own word, saying he is "the Saviour of the world." *John 4:39–42*

Key activities

John does not explain her five marriages. Some readers assume a sinful past. Others note that a woman could be widowed or divorced by her husbands with little choice of her own. Jesus names her situation plainly, and the text records no word of condemnation.

-
- 1 Came to draw water.** She came to Jacob's well at about the sixth hour, when Jesus was sitting there. *John 4:6-7*
 - 2 Questioned the stranger.** She asked why a Jew would ask her for a drink, and whether he was greater than "our father Jacob." *John 4:9-12*
 - 3 Asked for living water.** "Sir, give me this water, that I thirst not, neither come hither to draw." *John 4:15*
 - 4 Told the truth.** She said, "I have no husband," and Jesus said she had spoken well. *John 4:17-18*
 - 5 Raised the question of worship.** She asked whether God should be worshipped on the Samaritans' mountain or in Jerusalem. *John 4:19-24*
 - 6 Spoke of the Messiah.** "I know that Messiah cometh, which is called Christ." *John 4:25-26*
 - 7 Left her waterpot.** She went back into the city in such haste that she left her waterpot behind. *John 4:28*
 - 8 Brought her town to Jesus.** Her simple testimony led many Samaritans to believe and to come and hear him. *John 4:29-30, 39-42*
-

Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names the woman at the well.

Old Testament

Genesis 33:18–20; 48:22	Jacob's land near Shechem, given to Joseph (John 4:5)
2 Kings 17:24–41	Where the Samaritans and their mixed worship came from
Echo: Genesis 24; 29:1–12	Meetings at wells: Rebekah and Rachel
Echo: Jeremiah 2:13	God, "the fountain of living waters"

New Testament

John 4:1–42	The main account
John 7:37–39	Living water again, explained as the Spirit
Luke 10:30–37; 17:11–19	A good Samaritan and a grateful Samaritan leper
Acts 8:5–25	The gospel reaches Samaria, and many believe
Echo: Revelation 22:17	Take the water of life freely

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What does the woman do after Jesus says, "I that speak unto thee am he" (John 4:26–30)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Jesus began with a request for water rather than a sermon?
3. *Apply:* She left her waterpot behind. What everyday concern might you set down this week to pay attention to Jesus?
4. *Apply:* Her testimony was simple: "Come, see." Who is one person you could invite to church or to your group this week?